The Medicaid Readiness Checklist

What to gather, write down and ask about while Mom is still managing on her own.

Mom is doing fine on her own, and nobody is applying for anything. You'd just like to know what would be worth looking at if she ever needed long-term care. This is that list: what to gather, what to write down, and what to ask a professional about, a little at a time. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to get to when it suits you, not a verdict about Mom or about you.

Gather

- [ ] A recent statement or letter for each source of Mom's income, and a recent statement for each account she has. [1]
- [ ] The deed to her home, and the papers for any mortgage or loan against it. [1]
- [ ] Her life insurance policies and any annuity contracts.
- [ ] Trust papers, if there is a trust or anyone thinks there might be.

Write down

- [ ] What Mom does on her own today and any help she already gets, as what you've seen, with the date.
- [ ] The state she lives in, and whether she is married. If she is, her spouse's income, accounts and health belong on your lists too.
- [ ] Whose name is on the house and on each account, including anything owned jointly. Write what the paperwork shows, and change nothing.
- [ ] Anything significant that has been given away, transferred or put in someone else's name in recent years: what, roughly when, who was involved, and what paperwork exists. [1]
- [ ] What your family believes about Medicaid, such as “she has too much to qualify,” and where each idea came from.
- [ ] The changes that would send you back to this list: in her health or care needs, her finances or her marital status.

Ask about

- [ ] Which long-term care Medicaid programs Mom's state has, and what each looks at besides money, such as the level of care a person needs.
- [ ] How her state would look at her income, her accounts, her home and her insurance. Bring your lists; the comparing is a professional's part.
- [ ] Whether anything on your lists should be seen by an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional.
- [ ] Any change your family has talked about making, such as a gift or a new name on the deed. Bring it as a question, before anything is done.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather, write down and ask. It doesn't say whether Mom would qualify for Medicaid, what would count, or whether anything should change. Rules vary by state, so those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've seen what there is to gather, write down and ask about, area by area. The planning interview is the next step: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the kinds of records the Administration for Community Living says a state may ask for when someone applies for Medicaid: papers that verify finances, papers about a home and any loans on it, and an account of anything that was given away. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid